

Rhythm & Notation

Timing, measures, and counting — plus the treble staff symbols that tell you how long to hold a sound (or a silence).

PULSE

Beat / timing

The steady unit of time. Tempo is how fast those beats go by — measured in beats per minute.

GROUPING

Measure

A fixed number of beats between bar lines. Also called a bar. The time signature sets the size of each box.

SUBDIVISION

Counting

In 4/4, count **1·2·3·4**. Beat one carries the downbeat; subdivisions land on “and.”

TREBLE STAFF · ONE MEASURE OF 4/4



The treble (G) clef wraps the second line from the bottom — G4. Pitch rises as notes climb the staff; rhythm is written left to right.

TIME SIGNATURE

What 4/4 means

4 Top number — beats per measure.
4 Bottom number — which note value gets one beat (4 = quarter note).

Common time (c) is another way to write 4/4.

Bar lines close each measure; a double bar often ends a section.

ACCENT PATTERN IN 4/4

1 Downbeat
Strongest pulse in the bar

2 Weak
Keep the pulse steady

3 Medium
Secondary accent

4 Weak
Leads into the next 1



Whole note

4 BEATS

Open oval, no stem



Half note

2 BEATS

Open head + stem



Quarter note

1 BEAT

Filled head + stem



Eighth note

½ BEAT

Flag, or beam in pairs



Quarter rest

1 BEAT SILENT

Same length, no sound

CLEF

Treble clef

Assigns letter names to lines and spaces. Guitar melody and higher voices usually read here.

DURATION

Note = sound

Note shape shows length. Stem direction does not change duration — only how the page is filled.

SILENCE

Rest = wait

Rests use the same beat values as notes. Count them — they keep the measure honest.